Mobile Car Detailing at the Customer's Home

Free quick study · November 13, 2026 · General information, not financial or legal advice. Results are not guaranteed.

1. What it is

Mobile detailing means you drive to the customer's home or workplace and deep-clean their car there: exterior wash, wheels and tires, wax or sealant, and interior vacuum and wipe-down, finished with before and after photos. The customer does not leave home, so you can charge more than a basic car wash.

2. What customers pay (published 2026 figures)

Measure	Published figure	Source
Typical full detail (sedan)	about $275 per job; most charge $200–$300	MobileDetailingCost price index (444 providers)
Full detail, sedan / SUV-truck	$175–$300 / $225–$375	Restart guide (2026)
Exterior wash and spray sealant	$60–$90 (sedan)	Restart guide (2026)
Maintenance wash, repeat client	$45–$70 (sedan)	Restart guide (2026)
Time on site, full detail	2.5–4 hours	Restart guide; StartupCostGuide
Consumables cost per $175 job	about $30–$70 total true cost, before your labor	StartupCostGuide (2026)

3. Startup cost breakdown (lean, weekend-style start, using your own car)

Item	Typical cost	Source
Wash, foam, towels, wax	about $450	StartupCostGuide
Interior tools (extractor, steamer, vacuum)	about $400	StartupCostGuide
LLC / business license	about $200	StartupCostGuide
Insurance (first 6 months prepaid)	about $300	StartupCostGuide
Marketing (photos, flyers, signage)	about $200	StartupCostGuide
Working-capital reserve	about $400	StartupCostGuide
Typical lean total	about $2,000–$3,000 (budget table about $1,950; another guide $2,630)	StartupCostGuide; Restart guide

Bigger setups	$4,000–$7,000 part-time; $8,000–$15,000 full mobile rig (tank, generator, polisher)	StartupCostGuide

4. Requirements checklist

✓ **WITHOUT AI**	✗ **with AI**
✓ **NO REAL ESTATE needed**	✗ **needs real estate**
✓ **NO BUILDING needed**	✗ **needs building**
✓ **NO OFFICE needed (home-based)**	✗ **needs office**
✓ **NO LAND needed**	✗ **needs land**

You do need: basic detailing supplies, a way to reach customers (your own car works to start), the right insurance, and any local business registration required where you live.

5. Steps to start

• Register the business and check local rules, including rules on wastewater and storm drains (some cities fine runoff).
• Get insurance before the first paid job. General liability does not cover the customer's car, so ask about garage keepers coverage.
• Buy a lean kit: foam sprayer or bucket system, quality towels, wash mitts, wheel brushes, wax or sealant, vacuum, interior cleaner.
• Practice on your own and friends' cars, and take clear before and after photos.
• Set simple packages by vehicle size (exterior wash, interior, full detail) and publish the prices, using the ranges above.
• Post your before and after photos in neighborhood groups and marketplaces and book your first car this week.

6. How to get the first customers

• Start close to home: neighbors, local groups, and friends of friends. Keep the first jobs within about 10 miles to save driving time.
• Offer a founding-customer price for the first few cars in exchange for a review and a photo.
• Pitch small used-car lots and busy professionals who want a repeat maintenance wash every 2–4 weeks.
• Ask every customer for a review and a referral right after the job.

7. How it earns

You charge a flat price per car (published typical full detail about $275). Your costs are consumables, fuel, insurance and your time. Illustration only, not a promise: 2 full details per week at $275 would be $550/week, or about $2,200 for 4 weeks, before costs. Repeat maintenance washes from the same customers make income steadier.

8. Risks

• Slow start: expect fewer jobs in the first weeks until you have photos and reviews.
• A full detail takes 2.5–4 hours; your income is limited by your time, so quote carefully and add surcharges for pet hair or heavy dirt.
• Damage claims on the customer's car: insurance and before/after photos matter.

• Weather and seasons can cancel jobs; some cities restrict where wash water may drain.
• Physical work with chemicals; use proper safety gear.

9. Our rating

Difficulty: 2/5	Speed to profit: 4/5	First income: ~1–2 weeks (our estimate)

Sources (read Nov 13, 2026): MobileDetailingCost.com, "How Much to Charge for Mobile Detailing" mobiledetailingcost.com/articles/how-much-to-charge-for-mobile-detailing · Restart, "How to Start a Mobile-Detailing Business (2026 Guide)" restart.new/guides/how-to-start-a-mobile-detailing-business · StartupCostGuide, "Cost to Start a Mobile Detailing Business: $2K to $15K" startupcostguide.com/blog/cost-to-start-a-mobile-detailing-business-2026. Prices vary by city, vehicle size and condition.

Want a detailed study for your project or an AI assistant to run your business? Message us.